IR IV: International Security (AUW)

Political Science — Master Notes · by Jakob V. Stangel

Required reading: PG = Goldstein & Pevehouse, *International Relations*, ch. 5 (*International Conflict*) · **Bilgin, Pinar, "Security," in Berenskötter (ed.), *Concepts in International Relations* (2025), ch. 14.** · Lecturer: **Ayça Uygur Wessel.** Deck: "*International security.*"

Theme of the lecture (deck). Two moves. First, **unpack the concept of "security"** — it is *contested* and its real-world use is *political* (who gets to call something a "security" issue, and why). Then turn to **conflict and war** — how and why international (and internationalised) conflicts occur, read through the **levels of analysis.**

> ★ **The heart of the lecture:** "security" is not a neutral fact about the world but a **contested, political concept.** Three questions are always in play — **whose security?** (the *referent*: state · society · individual · humanity), **which threats?** (military vs non-military), and **is the state the protector or the threat?** Calling something a "security issue" is itself a **political act** (**securitisation**) that moves it out of normal politics. The different **IR theories** each answer "what is security?" differently, and **war** has causes at three **levels** — the individual, the state/domestic, and the anarchic system.

The red thread. *Security for whom, from what, and provided by whom — and who decides?* Hold those questions through the concept (Bilgin), the theories, and the causes of war (PG ch.5).

Key concepts / "modes" to use

- **Security = a contested concept** — thin agreement ("freedom from threats to core values"), deep disagreement on referent, threats, the state's role.
- **Referent object** ("whose security?") — **national/traditional** (state) · **societal** (community/identity) · **human** (individual) · **global** (humanity).
- **The state: protector (Hobbes) vs war-maker (Tilly)** — the four activities: war-making, state-making, protection, extraction ("protection racket").
- **Securitisation** (Wæver) — security as a **speech act**; framing an issue as an existential threat moves it beyond normal politics.
- **The security dilemma** (Herz) — self-help defence can be self-defeating.
- **IR theories & security** — realism (power under anarchy) · liberalism (cooperation/institutions) · constructivism (threats are constructed) · critical (security is political).
- **Causes of war — levels of analysis** (Waltz's *three images*): individual · domestic · systemic.
- **Types of war** (hegemonic/total/limited/civil/guerrilla) and **types of conflict** (ideas: ethnic/religious/ideological · interests: territorial/governmental/economic).

A. Unpacking "security" *(Bilgin ch.14 + deck)*

★ Security is a contested — and political — concept

Core: there is **thin agreement** (security = *freedom from threats to core values*, for individuals and groups) but **deep disagreement** on almost everything else. And crucially, **defining something *as* a security issue is a *political* act.**

- **What's contested (deck):** the **focus of inquiry** (whose security — individual, national, international, global?); the **types of threat** (military vs non-military); the **role of the state** (security *provider*, or a *threat* to security?).
- **★ The Kilis example (Bilgin's opener).** In 2016, rockets from IS-held northern Syria hit **Kilis, Türkiye**, killing 20+ over five months — yet the government did **not** officially call it a security threat (it portrayed the rockets as merely "falling from the sky"). This changed only in August 2016, when the government prepared a **ground incursion** into Syria and *then* declared the rockets **acts of terrorism threatening national security**. Why the change? **Politics** — initially it didn't want to be seen fighting a group with "Islamic" in its name; once ready to act, it named the enemy "DAESH." → *Politics is key to how — and whether — governments use the concept of security.*
- **Etymology:** "security" ← Latin ***securus*** ("without worry/concern"). Ironically, early usage saw feeling *too* secure as **bad** (breeds carelessness). **Hobbes** gave it its modern political shape (a strong authority as the condition for security).

Whose security? — the referent object

Core: the biggest disagreement is over the **referent object** — *who or what is to be secured?* The answer is **not fixed**; it changes with which threats which actors prioritise, and **the same event looks different depending on whose security you centre.**

Referent	"Security" asks…	Threat =
National / traditional (the **STATE**)	Is the state safe from **external** threats?	invasion, rival great powers
Societal (the **COMMUNITY**)	Can the group keep its **identity & way of life**?	migration, cultural erosion
Human (the **INDIVIDUAL**)	Are people safe in their **survival, well-being & rights**?	poverty, disease, their *own* government
Global (**HUMANITY**)	Are threats addressed at the level of **humanity/the planet**?	climate change, pandemics, nuclear war

- **Worked example (deck): global warming** looks like an economic issue to one actor, an existential threat to a low-lying island state, a human-security issue to the displaced. *Whose security you centre changes what you see.*

Types of threat — military vs non-military (and how they overlap)

Core: the traditional focus is **military** threats (invasion/territorial aggression, conventional war, nuclear escalation, interstate & civil conflict, coercion/shows of force, armed rebel groups) — but real-world threats are increasingly **non-military** (health, climate, migration), and the categories **overlap.**

- **South China Sea (deck's overlap case).** A **territorial** dispute (sovereignty, Spratly Islands, Exclusive Economic Zones) is *also* **economic** (oil, gas, fisheries), **strategic** (sea lanes — **~⅓ of global shipping** passes through), and **military** (bases, radar, missile shelters — e.g. China's runways on **Fiery Cross Reef**; "show-of-force" behaviour to assert dominance **without declaring war**). → *Analytical distinctions (military/economic/strategic) are tightly knotted in the real world.*

The state — security *provider* or *war-maker*?

Core: two opposed readings of the state's relation to security.

- **Provider (Hobbesian tradition):** the individual **gives up freedom** to be more secure, handing the **monopoly of violence** to the state, which embodies **national sovereignty.** A "security threat" = something posing an **existential threat to the state** (handled by defence, intelligence, law enforcement). *(This is the classic-realist starting point.)*
- **War-maker (Charles Tilly, 1985/1992):** states **earned their statehood through war-making** — "*war made the state and the state made war*" (cf. PET/PS on Tilly); war is the state's *modus operandi*; "**no war = no modern state.**" Tilly's **four activities** (he likens the early state to a **protection racket** — the deck's "Don Corleone" joke):

Activity	= eliminating / neutralising…
War-making	rivals **outside** the territory
State-making	rivals **inside** the territory
Protection	the enemies of its **clients**
Extraction	acquiring the **means** (tax, men) to do the first three

The concept's real-world history — from national → international → human security *(Bilgin)*

Core: the meaning of security was **never fixed**; different uses served different **political agendas**, and the "myth of origin" (US national security) is only one strand.

- **The "myth of origin" — US national security (post-1945).** "National security" rose to prominence in US debates over the post-war role of the US (rivalry with the USSR). Policymakers found it **flexible and catchy** — useful against isolationist/small-government opponents, to keep the US globally engaged and investing in the military. **Arnold Wolfers (1952):** national security as a form of **national interest.** Embedded institutionally via the **National Security Council** and **NSC-68 (1950)** → Truman's massive military build-up (peacetime military spending, newly justified by "national security"). *Contrary to realist assumptions,* US national security was **never only** about external military threats — "**making the world safe for US economic interests**" was central (the World Bank, IMF, GATT as "part and parcel of the security project") → a **creative repackaging** of economic interest as national security.
- **National vs international vs collective security.** The **referent** distinguishes them: US "national security" → the **state** is referent (threat = the USSR); UN "international security" → the **society of states** is referent (threat = another world war). **Collective security** = aggression against one is

aggression against all (global in scope; regulates relations *between* members) — *not* the same as an **alliance** like NATO (which defends *against* external threats). The League of Nations' collective security was paralysed by the **unanimity** rule; the UN fixed it with **majority** voting — but protected great powers with the **P5 veto** (so the US never has to act against its will — but any P5 can also block it). First real test: **North Korea's 1950 invasion** (the USSR was boycotting the Council, so it couldn't veto). → the "**Uniting for Peace**" mechanism lets the General Assembly recommend when the Council is deadlocked.

- **Human security — the alternative from *outside* the US.** Newly independent states, wary of superpower pacts (Nehru: "*every pact has brought insecurity*"), sought a "**third way**" focused on **sovereignty and development**, *not* a security frame (**Bandung Conference 1955**; Non-Aligned Movement; **New International Economic Order**). *(Box: **Iran 1953** — PM **Mosaddegh**, who nationalised the oil industry, was toppled by a **CIA-MI6** coup: the UK/US defended their **economic interests in the name of international security** against Iran's search for development.)* When the NIEO stalled, **non-state actors** took up the cause and made **human beings the referent** → "**human security,**" coined by **Mahbub ul Haq** ("secure human development"), embraced by the **UNDP in 1994.** Landmark: the **International Campaign to Ban Landmines (ICBL)** framed landmines as a human-security harm → the **1997 Mine Ban Treaty** + a Nobel Peace Prize (the **agency of non-state actors**).
- **The military-state frame returns (21st c.):** after **9/11**, NATO's collective-defence clause + the UN's collective-security mechanism let US national security be framed as *international* security → the **Global War on Terror.** Its flexibility let many governments re-label domestic opponents as "terrorists" (e.g. China and **Xinjiang**). And the **privatisation of security** — **Private Military Companies** like the **Wagner Group** (Russia in Ukraine) — sell security as a marketable good ("we sell a *concept* of security").

B. IR theories & security *(deck)*

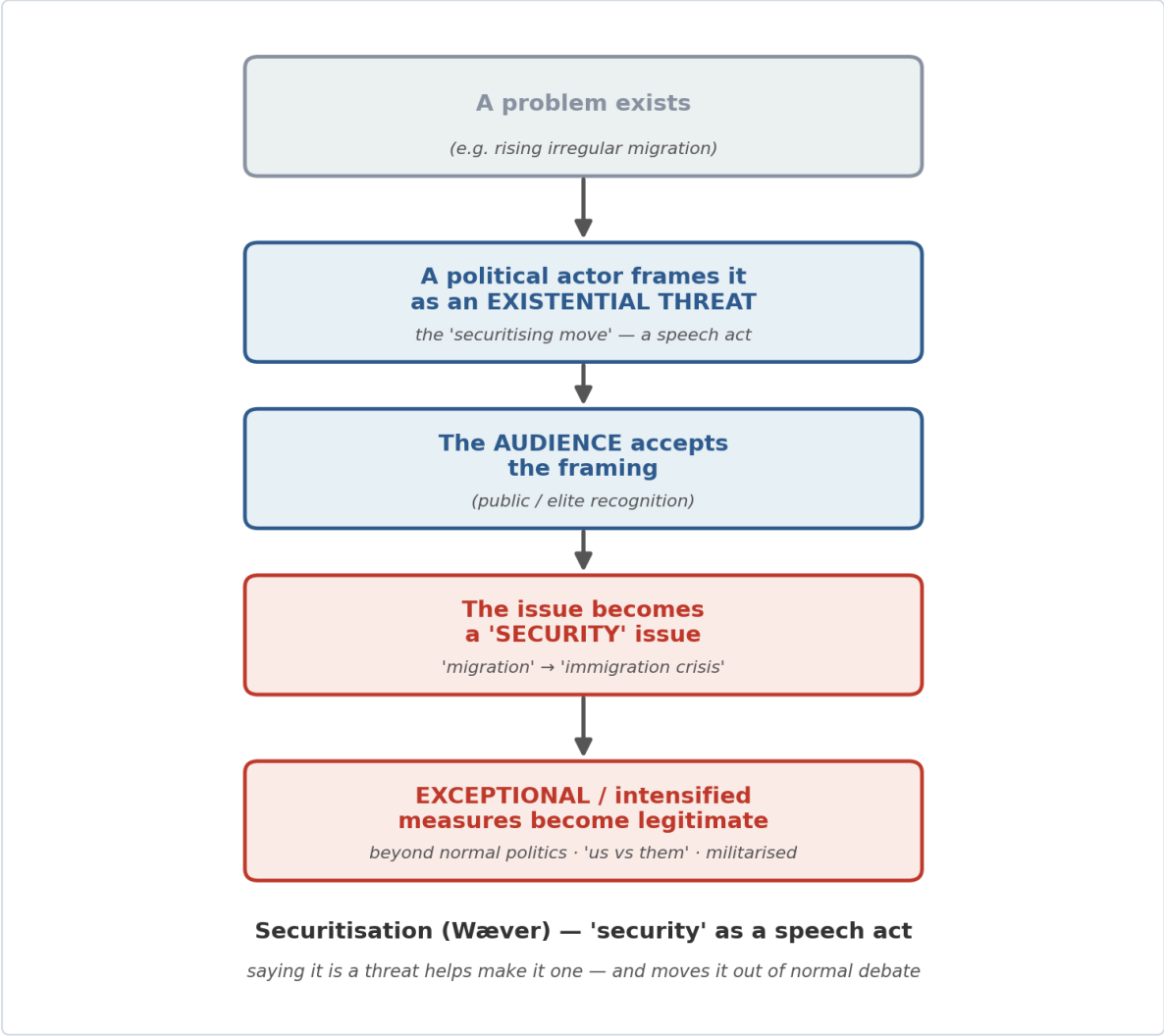
Core: each theory family answers "*what is security, and how do states pursue it?*" differently — and in a crisis, each **looks for different things.**

Theory	Security is…	The chain	In a crisis, it asks…
Realism	surviving under **anarchy**	anarchy → self-help → power/capabilities → **security competition**	military capabilities, alliances, relative power, strategic incentives
Liberalism	achieved through **cooperation**	self-interest → interdependence → **institutions** (info, monitoring, reciprocity) → cooperation	what **blocked** the mutual gains from cooperation? (+ domestic politics → preferences)
Constructivism	**what states make of it**	material capabilities → *(interaction + shared meanings)* → identity → threat perception → behaviour	**how did actors come to understand something as a threat?**
Critical IR	**political**	power shapes which threats/referents count	**whose** security? **who** defines the threat, and with what power? who is **protected vs marginalised**?

- *(Deck exercise: how would each theory explain **the USA's threats against Greenland**? Realism → strategic/Arctic position & relative power; liberalism → institutional/allied damage; constructivism → identity & how "threat" is framed; critical → whose security, whose Arctic, what hierarchy.)*

★ Securitisation — security as a "speech act" (Wæver / Copenhagen School)

Core: critics argue security **does not exist outside discourse** — an issue becomes a "security" issue only because an actor **frames** it as one. **Ole Wæver** calls this **securitisation**: *saying* something is an existential threat is also *doing* something. It is **not politically innocent** — it **removes the issue from normal political deliberation** ("beyond closed doors where experts decide"), lets governments claim **more resources** and **silence critics** in the name of unity against an "existential threat," creates an "**us vs them**" mindset, and often **militarises** the problem.



How to read it. The move that matters is **step 2 → 3**: a **securitising actor** *claims* existential threat, and the **audience** must **accept** it. Only then does the issue "become" security — and the payoff (step 5) is **exceptional powers** outside normal debate. Example (deck): "*increased irregular migration*" (a policy problem) vs "*immigration crisis*" (a securitised threat). **Climate change** is the live debate: securitising it could mobilise resources — but critics warn it creates a false "us vs them" (there is no "them" — *we* are the problem) and risks **militarising** a non-military issue.

Critical Security Studies — the academic critique of realism *(Bilgin)*

Core: IR's understanding of security was long dominated by a **realist** outlook (military threats *to states* from *outside*, met by military means; the state is both **referent** and **agent**). Critics — drawing on **Feminism, Frankfurt-School critical theory, post-structuralism, postcolonialism** — showed security is **socially constructed** and **political**, and re-opened *whose* security counts.

- **Wolfers' warning (1952):** national security is an "**ambiguous symbol**" — used without specification it "leaves room for more confusion than sound political counsel can afford." He split **objective** security (absence of threats to acquired values) from **subjective** (absence of *fear*) — both require judgement.
- **Common security** (Palme Commission, 1982): since there's **nowhere to hide from nuclear catastrophe**, the referent should be "**us all**" — pursue security *with* others, not against them. Rests on the **security dilemma** (Herz 1950): self-serving defence can be **self-defeating** (your build-up scares the other side → arms race → everyone less safe).
- **Gusterson:** realist security scholars not only **failed to predict the fall of the Berlin Wall (1989)** but "were unable to even entertain the possibility" — a blow to realism's authority (too much focus on military capabilities, too little on socio-political context).
- **Eurocentrism** (Barkawi & Laffey): security studied in Euro/Anglo-centric ways — **normative** (privileging EU/Western security — e.g. studying the 2015–16 Mediterranean "refugee crisis" only from Europe's side), **analytical** (Europe at the centre of the framework), **epistemological** (drawing only on the "European experience" as knowledge).
- **Feminist IR — Carol Cohn:** nuclear experts coded attention to the human costs of weapons as "**feminine**" and military might as "**strength**"; "**nuke-speak**" is abstract, gendered language that lets experts discuss weapons **without** confronting their human consequences. Realist security assessments are **not objective** but shaped by ideas of masculinity/femininity (cf. IR III).
- **Ontological security** (Mitzen, Rumelili): people/groups need a **stable identity**; a protracted conflict that threatens your *body* can **stabilise your identity** → actors whose identity is tied to fighting may **block peace** to preserve their "ontological security."
- **Relational approaches** (Bilgin): a state's "failure" to provide security is often a product of **international relations** (esp. the **colonial** legacy and the differential recognition of European vs African sovereignty), not just internal traits — so study security **relationally.**

*(Bilgin's concept web: **security** sits between its **contrast** — violence, war, insecurity, instability; its **cognate** — peace, stability; and its **supporting** concepts — threats, power, deterrence, development, and the physical/material/identity dimensions.)*

C. Causes of war *(PG ch.5 + deck)*

Types of war

Core: "war" (usually defined as ≥1,000 battle deaths) covers very different things:

Type	What it is
Hegemonic war	for control of the **entire world order** (a.k.a. world/global/systemic war) — last one was **WWII**; now probably impossible without destroying civilisation
Total war	to **conquer & occupy** another state (reach the capital, replace the government) — born with the **Napoleonic Wars**; the whole enemy society becomes a legitimate target
Limited war	objectives **short of** surrender/occupation (e.g. 1991 Gulf War retook Kuwait, didn't take Baghdad); **raids** = single-action limited wars
Civil war	factions **within a state** fighting to create/prevent a government or **secede** — often the most brutal
Guerrilla war	warfare **without front lines**; irregular forces hidden among civilians — harass rather than confront; civilians suffer most

★ Why does war break out? — the levels of analysis (Waltz's *three images*)

Core: most wars have **multiple causes at different levels.** The deck uses **Waltz's *Man, the State, and War* (1959)** "three images" — the **individual**, the **state/domestic**, and the **international system** — with **anarchy** as the *necessary* condition.

Level	The explanation	Key names
Individual	**human nature** (power-seeking) *and* **rational cost-benefit** calculation — war can be a *reasoned* choice (leaders may not bear its full cost); "**bad decision ≠ irrational decision**"; also **deviations from rationality** (bias, groupthink)	Thucydides, Machiavelli, Hobbes; **Fearon** (rationalist explanations)
Domestic	**regime type** & decision-making structures; powerful domestic actors, norms & **ideologies** (nationalism, religion); support for **irredentism/secession**; leaders playing to two audiences at once	**Putnam** (*two-level games*); democratic peace
Systemic	not human nature but the **anarchic system** that breeds fear & suspicion: "*wars occur because there is nothing to stop them from occurring*"; power-transition; deterrence vs arms races; long cycles	**Waltz** (1959); power-transition theory

- **Descriptive vs theoretical (PG):** a historian says "*the assassination of Franz Ferdinand caused WWI*"; a political scientist says the assassination was only the **catalyst** — the cause was **shifts in the balance of power.** The levels-of-analysis frame reminds us both (and more) operate at once.

What states fight *about* — conflicts of ideas & of interest *(PG §5.2–5.3)*

Core: PG sorts conflicts into six overlapping types — three over **ideas** (intangible: *who someone is*) and three over **interests** (tangible: *what someone has*).

- **Conflicts of IDEAS:**
  - **Nationalism** — devotion to one's nation over others; the link between **identity** and statehood. **Self-determination** (a nation should have its own state) constantly collides with **sovereignty/territorial integrity**.

- **Ethnic conflict** — hatred between **ethnic groups**; based not on what someone *does* but **who they are.** Driven by **ethnocentrism** (in-group bias) and, at its worst, **dehumanisation** of the out-group (the step that removes the restraints on violence — e.g. animal names, WWII propaganda).
- **Genocide** — the systematic extermination of a group; the extreme of dehumanisation.
- **Religious conflict** — sharpest where **fundamentalist** movements reject **secular** rules (of the state and the international system) as subordinate to divine law.
- **Ideological conflict** — often **less durable** than it looks (interests frequently drive the "ideological" clash).

- **Conflicts of INTEREST:**
  - **Territorial disputes** — over where **borders** run; especially intractable (states value home territory "fanatically"). **Irredentism** = regaining lost territory; **secession** = drawing a border around a *new* state (Kosovo 2008; South Sudan 2011).
  - **Control of governments** — over who runs an existing state.
  - **Economic conflict** — over trade, resources, money (often underlies the others — e.g. "conflict diamonds," the **Kimberley Process**).
  - *(PG's **Russia–Ukraine** example shows all of these at once: ethnic, religious, territorial (Crimea), and economic — combining rather than separate.)*

★ Synthesis — the two halves in one line

Core: the lecture's arc: **security is a political construction** (whose? from what? decided by whom — and *securitised* by whom), and **war has layered causes** (individual · domestic · systemic). The theories connect the halves: how you define **security** shapes what you count as a **cause of war** — a realist sees anarchy & power; a liberal sees failed cooperation; a constructivist sees threat-perceptions built through identity; a critical scholar asks whose security the whole conversation serves.

Cases & examples

- **Kilis, Türkiye (2016)** — a lethal cross-border military attack **not** called a "security" issue until it was politically useful. → *Illustrates: **securitisation** is political; naming a threat is a choice.*
- **South China Sea** — territorial + economic + strategic + military threats knotted together. → *Illustrates: **threats overlap**; the referent/threat you pick shapes the analysis.*
- **Iran 1953 (Mosaddegh)** — a coup to defend Western oil interests **framed as international security.** → *Illustrates: security as a **creative repackaging** of economic interest; the case for **human security**.*
- **ICBL / landmines** — non-state actors reframed landmines as a **human-security** harm → treaty + Nobel. → *Illustrates: the **agency of non-state actors** and the shift of referent from state to individual.*
- **The fall of the Berlin Wall (1989)** — realist security scholars couldn't even imagine it. → *Illustrates: the **limits of a purely military, state-centric** security lens (Gusterson).*

Key terms

Term	Meaning
Security (contested)	"Freedom from threats to core values" — but referent, threats & the state's role are all disputed
Referent object	*Whose* security: national/state · societal · human/individual · global
Securitisation (Wæver)	Framing an issue as an existential threat (a **speech act**) → moves it beyond normal politics
Security dilemma (Herz)	Self-help defence can be self-defeating (your build-up frightens others → arms race)
Human / common security	Referent = the individual / "us all" (vs the state)
Collective security vs alliance	Aggression against one = aggression against all (global) vs defence against an external enemy (NATO)
Tilly's four activities	War-making · state-making · protection · extraction ("the state as protection racket")
Levels of analysis / three images	Individual · domestic · systemic causes of war (Waltz 1959)
Irredentism / secession	Regaining lost territory / drawing a border around a new state
Ethnocentrism / dehumanisation	In-group bias / stripping the out-group of humanity (removes restraints on violence)

Exam pointers

- Explain why **security is "contested"** and **political** — use **Kilis** to show that *calling* something security is a choice.
- Lay out the **referent-object table** (national/societal/human/global) and show the **same event** looks different by referent.
- Define **securitisation** as a **speech act** and run the 5-step chain; give the **migration** or **climate** example and the *dangers* (beyond normal politics, "us vs them", militarisation).
- Contrast the **state as protector (Hobbes) vs war-maker (Tilly)** — reproduce Tilly's four activities.
- Run the **four IR theories on security** (realism/liberalism/constructivism/critical) on one crisis.
- Use the **levels of analysis / three images** to explain the outbreak of a war (individual **Fearon** · domestic **Putnam** · systemic **Waltz/anarchy**), and the **descriptive-vs-theoretical** (Franz Ferdinand = catalyst, not cause).
- Distinguish the **types of war** and the **six conflict types** (ideas vs interests) — with **Russia–Ukraine** as the "all at once" case.

Bridge. IR IV pulls the theory lectures (I–III) onto a single problem — **security & war** — and shows the payoff of theory choice: your theory decides *whose* security matters, *what* counts as a threat, and *why* war

happens. It also links back to **Tilly** (the war-made state, PS Lecture 2) and forward to the **use of force** (PG ch.6).

★ Fun facts & memorable details (IR IV: International Security)

> Sticky bits from international security.

- "**Security**" **once meant *carelessness*** — from Latin *securus* ("without worry"), and feeling **too** secure was considered a **flaw** (it made you drop your guard).
- **The rockets that "fell from the sky":** Türkiye refused to call a 5-month rocket barrage on **Kilis** a security threat — until it wanted to invade Syria. Same rockets, opposite label. Politics decides.
- **Tilly's one-liner:** "*war made the state, and the state made war*" — and his image of the early state as a **protection racket** (the deck jokes: not so different from **Don Corleone**).
- **The P5 veto exists because the US wanted one** — so the UN could never force it into an action it hadn't approved (the catch: any P5 can also block the US).
- **Collective security's first run was an accident:** the UN could act on **Korea (1950)** only because the **USSR was boycotting** the Security Council and wasn't there to veto.
- "**It's a boy**" and "**nuke-speak**" — Carol Cohn's evidence that even nuclear strategy is written in a **gendered** language that hides the human cost.
- **Realists didn't just miss the Berlin Wall — they couldn't imagine it** (Gusterson), which cracked realism's claim to "objective" security knowledge.
- **Climate change is "hard to securitise"** on purpose: there's **no "them"** — *we* are the threat, so the "us vs them" security reflex backfires.
